

WONDERFULLY MADE LABS

HELD

A Guided Journal for Heavy Hearts

GRIEF · STRESS · HURT · HEARTBREAK

Breath, prayer, and gentle steps
with the God who stays.

Find Him. Be with Him. Serve Him.

wonderfullymadelabs.com

Scripture quotations are from the World English Bible Update (WEBU), a public-domain translation — the same translation used throughout wonderfullymadelabs.com. The scientific notes in this journal are summarized honestly from the peer-reviewed studies listed in the References, in the plain language those studies support.

This journal is for encouragement and education. It is not medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment, and it is not a substitute for the care of a pastor, counselor, or physician.

Companion audio: Held — The Walking Audio Guide, one track for each day, made to be listened to on your walk.

A word before you begin

If you are holding this journal, something in your life hurts.

Maybe someone you love has died, and the world keeps moving as if nothing happened. Maybe a relationship ended, and the future you had pictured ended with it. Maybe it is not one thing but everything — stress layered on stress until your chest feels tight and your mind will not quiet down. Maybe someone hurt you, and the wound is not visible to anyone else.

This journal will not tell you to cheer up. It will not rush you, and it will not pretend that grief, stress, or heartbreak follow a schedule.

It will do something simpler, and truer: it will sit with you in the presence of a God who does not leave.

Over the next seven days — or seven weeks, or however long you need — you will read one promise of God at a time. You will breathe slowly, because He designed your body to settle as you do. You will walk gently, because He built movement into your frame as a real support for a heavy mind. You will pray honestly, the way the psalmists prayed — including the days when the only honest prayer is *How long?* And some days you will write a little. Some days you may not write at all, and that is allowed here.

Nothing in these pages is a test of your faith. A hard day is not a failed day. The promise underneath every page is not that you will hold on to God perfectly. It is that **He is holding you.**

> *"The LORD is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit." — Psalm 34:18 (WEBU)*

IF YOU DO NOT YET KNOW HIM

Everything in this journal rests on one true story: God so loved the world that He gave His Son, Jesus, so that whoever believes in Him should not perish, but have eternal life (John 3:16). Jesus lived the life we could not live, died the death our sins deserved, and rose again. The nearness this journal talks about is not a mood or a technique — it is a Person, and He invites you to come to Him exactly as you are: "Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matthew 11:28, WEBU). You can begin with a simple prayer: *Lord Jesus, I believe You died and rose for me. I turn from going my own way. Come into my life. Hold me.* He hears. He stays.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

One day at a time. Each day has the same gentle rhythm: a promise to read slowly, a short reflection, a breath prayer, a walk, and a writing invitation.

Everything is optional. If a prompt stirs up more pain than you can carry today, skip it. Research is honest on this point: for some people, on some days, writing at length about a loss can keep the mind circling rather than bring relief. A short page is a faithful page. Resting is a faithful page too.

Walk as you are able. Ten unhurried minutes counts. If walking is difficult for you, sit outside, or by a window, and let the same words meet you there.

Use the audio companion. Each day of this journal has a matching track in *Held — The Walking Audio Guide* , made to be listened to on your walk: the same promise, the same breath prayer, time to simply walk with Him.

Bring people in. God made us for one another, and research on human health keeps confirming what Scripture has always said: we were not built to carry this alone. When a day's page suggests sharing something with a trusted person, consider it a real part of the care, not an extra.

A NECESSARY WORD OF CARE

Grief and deep stress take a real toll on the body — on sleep, appetite, concentration, and health itself. That toll is well documented, and it is one more reason to be gentle with yourself and to accept help. This journal is a companion, not a clinician.

If your grief, anxiety, or sadness feels persistent, heavy, and impairing — if daily life is becoming unmanageable — please talk with a counselor, your pastor, or your doctor. Seeking that help is wisdom, not weak faith.

If you are in crisis or thinking about ending your life, please reach out now: call or text **988** (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, US) or go to your nearest emergency room. You do not have to face this alone, and your life is precious to God.

D A Y ONE

He Is Near

> *"The LORD is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit." — Psalm 34:18 (WEBU)*

READ IT AGAIN, SLOWLY

Read the verse once more, out loud if you can. Notice what it does not say. It does not say God is near to those who have pulled themselves together. It does not say He waits at a distance until the crying stops. It says He is near — present tense — *to those who have a broken heart.* Brokenness is not the barrier to His presence. In His own words, it is the address where He promises to be found.

And your tears are not invisible to Him: "You count my wanderings. You put my tears into your container. Aren't they in your book?" (Psalm 56:8, WEBU). The God who numbers galaxies stoops to keep count of your tears. Not one of them falls unnoticed. Not one of them is wasted.

HIS DESIGN — A BODY THAT GRIEVES

Grief is not only an emotion. Bereavement and heavy stress register in the body — in broken sleep, a weakened appetite, a racing or heavy heart, exhaustion that rest doesn't seem to fix. Medical research on bereavement documents this toll plainly. So if your body feels unsteady right now, you are not imagining it, and you are not failing spiritually. You are a soul *and* a body, fearfully and wonderfully made — and the body He made you in is carrying something heavy.

That is also why this journal pairs every promise with something bodily: breath, walking, rest. We do not care for the soul by ignoring the body He gave it to live in.

BREATHE AND PRAY

Sit comfortably. Breathe in slowly through your nose, and as you breathe in, pray: **"You are near…"** Breathe out slowly, and finish: **"…to the brokenhearted."** Repeat for one unhurried minute. There is no magic pace and no performance here — slow, gentle breathing is simply one of the ways your Creator designed your body to settle, and research links it to calmer body rhythms and modest relief from stress. Let the words ride the breath He gave you (Genesis 2:7).

WALK WITH HIM

Walk slowly for about ten minutes — around your block, your garden, a quiet path. You are not exercising your way out of grief; you are walking with a God who is near. As you walk, look for one small sign of His care in the created world: light through leaves, birdsong, cool air. Whisper the verse once, mid-walk: *The LORD is near to those who have a broken heart.*

WRITE — JUST A LITTLE

Finish these sentences, in a word or a line each. Stop whenever you need to.

Today, the heaviest part is…

One thing I wish people understood is…

Lord, what I most need from You today is…

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE BOOK

You do not have to feel His nearness for it to be true. Feelings are weather; His promise is climate. He is near — because He said so, and He does not lie.

D A Y TWO

He Binds Up Wounds

> *"He heals the broken in heart, and binds up their wounds." — Psalm 147:3 (WEBU)*

READ IT AGAIN, SLOWLY

The verse before this promise, in the same psalm, says He counts the stars and calls them all by name. Then — in the very next breath — He is bending over broken hearts, binding wounds. The God of galaxies does close, careful work. Binding a wound is not dramatic. It is slow, gentle, near, and repeated: clean, cover, protect, check again tomorrow. If your healing feels undramatic and slow, that does not mean it isn't happening. It may mean it is happening the way wounds actually heal.

HIS DESIGN — HOW HEALING ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Your body was designed by God to repair itself in stages, and almost all of that repair is invisible while it happens. Skin closes from the edges inward. Broken bones knit over weeks of quiet. Much of the body's deepest restoration happens in sleep — and sleep is often exactly what grief disturbs. Here the research offers a gentle, practical kindness: regular physical activity, even walking, is associated in study after study with modestly better sleep — falling asleep a little more easily, sleeping a little more soundly. You cannot force your heart to heal faster. But you can give your body the conditions its Maker built it to heal in: daylight, movement, rest.

BREATHE AND PRAY

Breathe in slowly: **"You heal the broken in heart..."** Breathe out slowly: **"...and bind up their wounds."** Repeat for a minute. As you breathe out, let your shoulders drop. Picture His hands — patient, unhurried, kind — doing the binding you cannot do for yourself.

WALK WITH HIM

If you can, walk somewhere living today — trees, a garden, water, open sky — for fifteen to twenty minutes. Early research on walking in nature found something quietly beautiful: a walk among trees, rather than along a busy road, eased the mind's circling — the replaying, re-arguing, re-living that grief and heartbreak stir up. Leave the

headphones off for at least part of the walk. Notice five things you can see, four you can hear, three you can feel. Creation is one of the classrooms where God teaches our hearts that He is attentive to small things.

WRITE — JUST A LITTLE

One wound I keep expecting to be "over" by now is…

A way I have seen God bind up a wound before — in my life, or in someone I love — is…

Today, I will give my body one condition for healing: (circle of one — daylight, a walk, an earlier night, a real meal, water). Mine is…

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE BOOK

Binding takes time, and the Binder is patient. You do not need to be healed by Friday. You need only stay near the Healer.

D A Y THREE

He Will Never Leave

> *"The LORD himself is who goes before you. He will be with you. He will not fail you nor forsake you. Don't be afraid. Don't be discouraged." — Deuteronomy 31:8 (WEBU)*

READ IT AGAIN, SLOWLY

Moses spoke these words at a border — to a man, and a people, about to walk into a future they could not see, without the leader they had always known. Maybe you are standing at a border too: the first season without them, the first month in a different life than the one you planned. God's word for border-crossings is not a map. It is a presence: *He goes before you. He will be with you. He will not fail you nor forsake you.*

And it is not a promise He made once and forgot. Centuries later it is repeated to God's people, and anchored in His own mouth: "I will in no way leave you, neither will I in any way forsake you" — so that we can say with courage, "The Lord is my helper. I will not fear" (Hebrews 13:5–6, WEBU).

People may leave. Plans may leave. The person you were before this loss may feel like she or he has left too. *He will not.*

HIS DESIGN — MADE FOR ONE ANOTHER

One of the largest findings in all of health research is also one of the plainest truths in Genesis — "It is not good for man to be alone." Across 148 studies and more than 300,000 people, stronger social relationships were associated with a markedly greater likelihood of survival — an effect researchers compared in size to well-known risks to health. God did not design you to grieve in a sealed room. He designed you to be carried, in part, by people: a friend on the other end of the phone, a church that brings meals, someone who simply sits with you and says little.

Grief and heartbreak tempt us to withdraw — sometimes because we're exhausted, sometimes because we believe no one understands. Some solitude is healthy. But let today's design truth be simple: **connection is not a distraction from healing. It is one of its God-given means.**

BREATHE AND PRAY

Breathe in slowly: **"You go before me..."** Breathe out slowly: **"...and You will not leave me."** Repeat for a minute. Before you today is a future you can't see. Before you today is also Him — already there.

WALK WITH HIM

Walk ten to fifteen minutes. If you can, invite someone — a friend, a family member, someone from church — to walk with you, even for part of the way. Walking side by side has a gentle way of loosening words that won't come face to face. If no one is available today, walk and talk to God out loud about the future you're afraid of. He is not put off by an honest conversation. The psalms are full of them.

WRITE — JUST A LITTLE

The future I am most afraid of right now is...

One person God has used to carry me, even a little, is...

Someone I could let in a little more — and one small way I could do it this week — is...

If writing about the person who left, or the one who hurt you, starts your mind circling and your distress climbing, stop. Return to the breath prayer. That is not avoidance; the research — and this journal — are clear that you are allowed to set the pen down.

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE BOOK

You may feel alone today. You are not abandoned. There is a difference, and on the hard days the difference has a name: *He will not fail you nor forsake you.*

D A Y FOUR

His Love Cannot Be Lost

> *"For I am persuaded that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor things present, nor things to come, nor powers, nor height, nor depth, nor any other created thing will be able to separate us from God's love which is in Christ Jesus our Lord." — Romans 8:38–39 (WEBU)*

READ IT AGAIN, SLOWLY

Paul made a list of everything that might conceivably come between you and the love of God — and he did not spare the biggest items. *Death* itself is on the list, and it is crossed out. *Things present* — the diagnosis, the empty chair, the ended relationship, the debt, the diagnosis in your inbox — crossed out. *Things to come* crossed out too, in advance. Then, lest anything be missed, he closed the list with a sweep: *nor any other created thing.* There is no fine print. Nothing in all creation — including your loss, your failure, your wandering, your worst day — can separate you from His love.

If your heartbreak came by someone's leaving, hear this with both ears: a person may withdraw their love. God cannot be talked out of His. And He does not love you grimly, at a distance. "The LORD, your God, is among you, a mighty one who will save. He will rejoice over you with joy. He will calm you in his love. He will rejoice over you with singing." (Zephaniah 3:17, WEBU). Over *you* . With *singing* .

HIS DESIGN — NEW MERCIES, EVERY MORNING

Jeremiah wrote the book of Lamentations — the Bible's own book of grief — and in the middle of it he wrote this: "It is because of the LORD's loving kindnesses that we are not consumed, because his mercies don't fail. They are new every morning. Great is your faithfulness." (Lamentations 3:22–23, WEBU).

Notice what your Creator built into creation itself: a daily reset. Light returns every morning whether you feel hopeful or not. Your body runs on rhythms — sleep and waking, hunger and fullness, breath after breath — that begin again and again. He designed a world, and a body, that starts fresh each day, because He is a God whose mercies do. You do not need a lifetime's worth of strength today. You need today's mercy — and it arrived this morning, before you woke up, and it will arrive again tomorrow.

Research on people under stress adds a small, fitting note: those who experience God's support and nearness in hardship tend to adjust better than those who feel abandoned by Him. That is not a transaction — His love does not depend on your adjustment. It is simply one more witness that resting in His love is good for the whole person He made.

BREATHE AND PRAY

Breathe in slowly: **"Great is Your faithfulness..."** Breathe out slowly: **"...Your mercies are new every morning."** Repeat for a minute. Yesterday's grief does not get the final word over today. His mercy got here first.

WALK WITH HIM

Walk fifteen minutes, morning if you can. As you walk, quietly name the items on Paul's list that your heart has been fearing — *death... things present... things to come...* — and after each one, answer with the verse's verdict: *"cannot separate me from Your love."* Let your steps keep time with it. Step. *Cannot separate.* Step. *Cannot separate.*

WRITE — JUST A LITTLE

A lie my pain keeps telling me about God's love is...

The truth, in Scripture's own words, is... *(Copy out Romans 8:38–39, or Zephaniah 3:17, by hand. Handwriting slows the mind in a way typing does not.)*

One mercy I can already see this morning — however small — is...

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE BOOK

You are not hard to love, and you are not almost loved. In Christ, you are loved with a love that nothing in creation can interrupt. Sleep tonight under that sentence.

D A Y FIVE

Cast Your Cares

> *"In nothing be anxious, but in everything, by prayer and petition with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your thoughts in Christ Jesus." — Philippians 4:6–7 (WEBU)*

READ IT AGAIN, SLOWLY

Anxiety is a guard posted at the wrong door — your mind standing watch all night over things it cannot control. God does not scold the watchman. He offers a transfer: bring the whole list to *Him* — "in everything, by prayer and petition" — and receive in exchange a different guard entirely: "the peace of God… will guard your hearts and your thoughts."

Notice the sequence. The peace is promised not when the circumstances resolve, but when the requests are made known to God. He does not say, *Wait until it works out, then you may rest.* He says: hand it over, and let My peace stand watch instead of your worry.

Peter says the same thing from the other side, describing prayer as an act of casting — throwing a weight onto stronger shoulders — "casting all your worries on him, because he cares for you" (1 Peter 5:7, WEBU). *Because He cares for you.* The transfer works because of who is receiving the weight.

HIS DESIGN — THE PHYSIOLOGY OF A RACING MIND

God designed your body with an alarm system, and it is a gift: when danger is real, adrenaline and cortisol sharpen you to respond. But an alarm designed for minutes can get stuck on for weeks — after a death, a betrayal, a breakup, a season of relentless stress. A tight chest, a churning stomach, a mind replaying conversations at 2 a.m.: that is an alarm system doing overtime, not a faith failure.

And He built in a brake. Slow, gentle breathing — especially letting the out-breath run a little longer than the in-breath — is associated in research with calmer body rhythms: across randomized trials, breathwork brought small-to-moderate reductions in stress, anxiety, and low mood; in one study, just five minutes a day of unhurried, exhale-focused breathing improved people's mood across a month. The effects are modest and honest — breathing is not medicine, and it will not erase a real loss. But it is

a real, God-designed pathway: the breath He breathed into you in the beginning can help settle the body He still sustains.

BREATHE AND PRAY

This is today's practice. Breathe in slowly to a count of about four. Breathe out more slowly, to a count of about six, as if through a narrow straw. With the in-breath, pray: **"I bring this to You…"** With the long out-breath: **"…and Your peace will guard me."** Continue for two or three minutes. If you feel light-headed, breathe normally and rest; comfort is the rule, never strain.

WALK WITH HIM

Walk fifteen to twenty minutes at a pace that lets you breathe through your nose. Each time a worry surfaces mid-walk — and it will — practice the transfer in one sentence: *"Lord, this one too: _____."* Then return your attention to something present: your steps, the sky, the sound of your own breathing. Worry will visit. It does not get to lead the walk.

WRITE — JUST A LITTLE (WITH A TIMER)

Set a timer for ten minutes — no more. On one side of the page, list the specific worries you are handing to God tonight, as short petitions: *"Lord, I give You _____."* When the timer ends, close the list, read Philippians 4:6–7 once more, and be done. Structured and time-limited is the design here on purpose: an open-ended spiral of anxious writing helps no one, and the research on writing after loss and separation is honest about that. If anxiety is a frequent, heavy companion, a counselor can give you more tools — receiving them is strength, not failure.

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE BOOK

Tonight, something will stand guard over your heart and thoughts. It does not have to be your worry. By His promise, it can be His peace.

D A Y SIX

Through the Valley

> *"Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me. Your rod and your staff, they comfort me." — Psalm 23:4 (WEBU)*

READ IT AGAIN, SLOWLY

Three honest words hold this verse together: *walk* , *through* , *with* .

Walk — not run, not leap, not be airlifted out. The pace of grief is a walking pace, and the Shepherd matches it. *Through* — the valley is a passage, not a permanent address; it has another side, even when you cannot see it from here. And *with* — the promise of Psalm 23 is not the absence of the valley. It is the presence of the Shepherd in it: *"for you are with me."*

He told you the same about every deep place: "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you, and through the rivers, they will not overflow you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be burned, and flame will not scorch you." (Isaiah 43:2, WEBU). Not *if* you pass through. *When.* And not alone when you do.

HIS DESIGN — LAMENT IS BUILT IN

Did you know that roughly a third of the Psalms — God's own prayer book — are laments? Crying out, asking *how long* , naming the pain in God's presence: this is not the opposite of faith. In Scripture, it is one of faith's native languages. In Psalm 42, the writer preaches to his own soul mid-pain: "Why are you in despair, my soul? Why are you disturbed within me? Hope in God! For I shall still praise him for the saving help of his presence." (Psalm 42:5, WEBU).

Grief also moves the way the valley winds — forward, then back, sometimes in the same hour: a good morning, a song in a store that undoes you. Researchers who study bereavement describe the same rhythm, and they note something your Shepherd already knows: most people, given time, rest, faith, movement, and the company of others, find their way through grief in the ordinary course of life. Waves are not regression. A wave is just the valley curving. Keep walking.

And keep the walk literal, too: across 75 randomized trials, walking itself was linked with meaningful reductions in symptoms of depression and anxiety. Day after day, one walk at a time, you are caring for the body your grief lives in.

BREATHE AND PRAY

Breathe in slowly: **"You are with me..."** Breathe out slowly: **"...in this valley too."** Repeat for a minute. The Shepherd's rod defends; His staff draws near and guides. Both are for the dark stretches. Especially for the dark stretches.

WALK WITH HIM

Take today's longest walk — twenty to thirty minutes if you are able, somewhere with a view of distance if you can: a ridge, a riverbank, the end of a long street. You are practicing a picture: the valley has another side. Walk at grief's pace without apology. If a wave rises mid-walk, let it. Tears on the path are allowed; the Shepherd is not embarrassed by them, and the One who keeps your tears in His book is not hurried.

WRITE — A LAMENT OF YOUR OWN

The psalms of lament follow a simple pattern. Borrow it, briefly, in your own true words (ten minutes is plenty):

Turn: *Lord, I come to You because…*

Tell: *Here is what has happened, and what it has cost…*

Ask: *Here is what I am asking You for…*

Trust: *And here is what I know is still true about You…*

Close by copying Psalm 23:4 by hand. If today the "trust" line is only *"You are with me,"* that is enough. It was enough for David.

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE BOOK

You are not lost in the valley. You are being led through it, at walking pace, by a

Shepherd who has never once lost a sheep He went after.

D A Y SEVEN

Strength for the Next Step

> *"...but those who wait for the LORD will renew their strength. They will mount up with wings like eagles. They will run, and not be weary. They will walk, and not faint." — Isaiah 40:31 (WEBU)*

READ IT AGAIN, SLOWLY

Read the promise in reverse order, the way a grieving person actually lives it: *walk, and not faint* comes before running, and running before flying. God's promise to the weary is not that they will skip the walking. It is that in the waiting — in the hoping, in the staying near — strength gets *renewed* : exchanged, the way you hand over an empty vessel and receive a full one. The everlasting God, the Creator of the ends of the earth, "doesn't faint. He isn't weary" (Isaiah 40:28, WEBU) — and He gives His unwearied strength to people who have none: "He gives power to the weak. He increases the strength of him who has no might." (Isaiah 40:29, WEBU).

Notice who this promise is for: not the strong, but the ones who have *no might* . If that is you today, you qualify completely.

HIS DESIGN — SMALL STEPS, REALLY

Everything in this journal has been deliberately small: ten minutes, one verse, a few lines, one breath prayer. That is not a lowered standard; it is how your Maker built recovery into bodies and lives — incrementally. The research agrees with the design. In large prospective studies, even about *half* the standard weekly activity guideline — roughly 75 minutes a week of brisk walking — was associated with meaningfully lower risk of depression; the full amount, around 150 minutes, with lower risk still. You do not climb out of a hard season in one heroic effort. You walk out of it the way you walked into this week: one ordinary, grace-carried day at a time.

And keep the end in view. The story God is telling does not terminate in the valley. It terminates here: "He will wipe away every tear from their eyes. Death will be no more; neither will there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain any more. The first things have passed away." (Revelation 21:4, WEBU). Grief is real. It is not final. Hope, in Christ, is not wishful thinking — it is a Person's promise about a coming morning.

BREATHE AND PRAY

Breathe in slowly: **"I wait for You, Lord..."** Breathe out slowly: **"...renew my strength."** Repeat for a minute. Waiting, in Scripture, is not passivity — it is hope with its eyes open, the posture of someone who knows Who is coming.

WALK WITH HIM

Walk twenty minutes, and some of it — a street, a hill, a few minutes more than comfort suggests — just slightly beyond easy, if your body allows. Not to prove anything. Just to feel, in your own frame, Isaiah's sequence in miniature: you walked, and you did not faint. End your walk standing still for a moment, and pray Romans 15:13 over yourself and over everyone you know who is grieving: *"Now may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, that you may abound in hope in the power of the Holy Spirit."* (WEBU).

WRITE — ONE NEXT STEP

The smallest faithful next step in my life — not the whole road, just the next step — is...

One thing I want to remember from this week, for the next hard day, is...

A note to my future self, for a day when the valley curves back: *(Write it kindly. Seal it here. God will hold the rest.)*

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE BOOK

You began this week, perhaps, wondering if you would make it through seven days. You have — carried. The same hands hold tomorrow. *Those who wait for the LORD will renew their strength.*

KEEP WALKING

For the weeks after this one — return to any day, in any order, whenever the valley curves. These verses are the trail markers. All are WEBU.

When the weight feels crushing: "Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart; and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light." — Matthew 11:28–30

When you need peace that circumstances can't give: "Peace I leave with you. My peace I give to you; not as the world gives, I give to you. Don't let your heart be troubled, neither let it be fearful." — John 14:27

When trouble feels louder than truth: "I have told you these things, that in me you may have peace. In the world you have trouble; but cheer up! I have overcome the world." — John 16:33

When fear of tomorrow rises: "Don't you be afraid, for I am with you. Don't be dismayed, for I am your God. I will strengthen you. Yes, I will help you. Yes, I will uphold you with the right hand of my righteousness." — Isaiah 41:10

When you feel overlooked: "The LORD will also be a high tower for the oppressed; a high tower in times of trouble." — Psalm 9:9 · And: "The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; and he knows those who take refuge in him." — Nahum 1:7

When your heart is overwhelmed: "From the end of the earth, I will call to you when my heart is overwhelmed. Lead me to the rock that is higher than I." — Psalm 61:2

When you are ready to comfort someone else: "Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our affliction, that we may be able to comfort those who are in any affliction, through the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God." — 2 Corinthians 1:3–4

The comfort God gives you in this season is not only for you. One day — not today, and not on any schedule — it will become, in His hands, comfort for someone walking the valley behind you. That is how His kingdom has always healed the world: the comforted become comforters.

THE SCIENCE, HONESTLY

A short note on what the research in this journal does and does not say.

Wonderfully Made Labs exists to be faith-honest and science-true. So, plainly: the practices in this journal — slow breathing, regular walking, time outdoors, prayer and honest writing, rest, and the company of others — are genuinely supported by research as *supports* for people under stress. None of them is a cure, and this journal promises comfort and companionship, not recovery on a timeline. Scripture carries the comfort here; the science simply confirms that the rhythms God built into your body are real pathways of care.

Breathing. Slow breathing (under roughly ten breaths a minute) is associated with calmer autonomic rhythms and increased heart-rate variability, and across randomized trials breathwork produced small-to-moderate reductions in stress, anxiety, and depressive symptoms. No single pace is proven best, and breathing is not a treatment for anxiety or depression. (Zaccaro et al., 2018; Laborde et al., 2022; Fincham et al., 2023.)

Walking and movement. An umbrella review of 97 systematic reviews found medium benefits of physical activity for depression, anxiety, and distress. In prospective studies, roughly 75 minutes a week of brisk walking was associated with 18% lower risk of depression, and roughly 150 minutes with 25% lower risk — associations with risk, not guarantees for any one person. Across 75 trials, walking reduced symptoms of depression and anxiety. Regular activity also modestly improves sleep. Evidence specific to grief is early but encouraging: bereaved people report walking and other activity as sources of relief, expression, and support. (Singh et al., 2023; Pearce et al., 2022; Xu et al., 2024; Kredlow et al., 2015; Williams et al., 2021; WHO, 2020.)

Nature. In early research, a walk in a natural setting — unlike a walk along a busy road — reduced rumination and lifted mood; broader reviews of outdoor activity find similar support. (Bratman et al., 2015; Coventry et al., 2021.)

Prayer and faith. Research finds that people who cope with hardship through a sense of God's support and nearness tend to adjust better than those who feel punished or abandoned by God; care that honors a person's faith also tends to help that person more. Science cannot measure God's presence or prove His answers to prayer — and this journal does not ask it to. His nearness is His promise, and we take Him at His word. (Ano & Vasconcelles, 2005; Captari et al., 2018.)

Writing. Across many studies, expressive writing brings a real but small average benefit — and it is not right for everyone on every day: in one trial with recently separated adults, deep expressive writing *slowed* recovery for those searching hardest for meaning, and studies in bereavement found no benefit from disclosure exercises. That is why every prompt in this journal is optional, brief, and paired with grounding — and why setting the pen down is always a faithful option. (Frattaroli, 2006; Sbarra et al., 2013; Stroebe et al., 2002.)

One another. Across 148 studies and over 300,000 people, stronger social relationships were associated with a 50% greater likelihood of survival. God made us for each other; the data merely agrees. (Holt-Lunstad, Smith & Layton, 2010.)

Grief itself. Bereavement takes a documented toll on health, and even professional grief therapy shows modest average effects for most grievers — which is why this journal aims at what a journal can honestly offer: the presence of God, the care of His people, and gentle daily practices. Most bereaved people do find their way through, in time. Persistent, impairing grief deserves professional and pastoral care. (Stroebe, Schut & Stroebe, 2007; Currier, Neimeyer & Berman, 2008.)

REFERENCES

1. Ano, G. G., & Vasconcelles, E. B. (2005). Religious coping and psychological adjustment to stress: A meta-analysis. *Journal of Clinical Psychology, 61* (4), 461–480. https://doi.org/10.1002/jclp.20049 2. Balban, M. Y., et al. (2023). Brief structured respiration practices enhance mood and reduce physiological arousal. *Cell Reports Medicine, 4* (1), 100895. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.xcrm.2022.100895 3. Bratman, G. N., Hamilton, J. P., Hahn, K. S., Daily, G. C., & Gross, J. J. (2015). Nature experience reduces rumination and subgenual prefrontal cortex activation. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 112* (28), 8567–8572. https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1510459112 4. Bull, F. C., et al. (2020). World Health Organization 2020 guidelines on physical activity and sedentary behaviour. *British Journal of Sports Medicine, 54* (24), 1451–1462. https://doi.org/10.1136/bjsports-2020-102955 5. Captari, L. E., et al. (2018). Integrating clients' religion and spirituality within psychotherapy: A comprehensive meta-analysis. *Journal of Clinical Psychology, 74* (11), 1938–1951. https://doi.org/10.1002/jclp.22681 6. Coventry, P. A., et al. (2021). Nature-based outdoor activities for mental and physical health: Systematic review and meta-analysis. *SSM – Population Health, 16* , 100934. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ssmph.2021.100934 7. Currier, J. M., Neimeyer, R. A., & Berman, J. S. (2008). The effectiveness of psychotherapeutic interventions for bereaved persons: A comprehensive quantitative review. *Psychological Bulletin, 134* (5), 648–661. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.134.5.648 8. Ferrari, M., et al. (2019). Self-compassion interventions and psychosocial outcomes: A meta-analysis of RCTs. *Mindfulness, 10* (8), 1455–1473. https://doi.org/10.1007/s12671-019-01134-6 9. Fincham, G. W., Strauss, C., Montero-Marin, J., & Cavanagh, K. (2023). Effect of breathwork on stress and mental health: A meta-analysis of randomised-controlled trials. *Scientific Reports, 13* , 432. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-022-27247-y 10. Frattaroli, J. (2006). Experimental disclosure and its moderators: A meta-analysis. *Psychological Bulletin, 132* (6), 823–865. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.823 11. Hanson, S., & Jones, A. (2015). Is there evidence that walking groups have health benefits? A systematic review and meta-analysis. *British Journal of Sports Medicine, 49* (11), 710–715. https://doi.org/10.1136/bjsports-2014-094157 12. Holt-Lunstad, J., Smith, T. B., & Layton, J. B. (2010). Social relationships and mortality risk: A meta-analytic review. *PLoS Medicine, 7* (7), e1000316. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pmed.1000316 13. Kredlow, M. A., Capozzoli, M. C., Hearon, B. A., Calkins, A. W., & Otto, M. W. (2015). The effects of physical activity on sleep: A meta-analytic review. *Journal of Behavioral Medicine, 38* (3), 427–449. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10865-015-9617-6 14. Laborde, S., et al. (2022). Effects of

voluntary slow breathing on heart rate and heart rate variability: A systematic review and a meta-analysis. *Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews, 138* , 104711. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.neubiorev.2022.104711 15. Pearce, M., et al. (2022). Association between physical activity and risk of depression: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *JAMA Psychiatry, 79* (6), 550–559. https://doi.org/10.1001/jamapsychiatry.2022.0609 16. Sbarra, D. A., Boals, A., Mason, A. E., Larson, G. M., & Mehl, M. R. (2013). Expressive writing can impede emotional recovery following marital separation. *Clinical Psychological Science, 1* (2), 120–134. https://doi.org/10.1177/2167702612469801 17. Singh, B., et al. (2023). Effectiveness of physical activity interventions for improving depression, anxiety and distress: An overview of systematic reviews. *British Journal of Sports Medicine, 57* (18), 1203–1209. https://doi.org/10.1136/bjsports-2022-106195 18. Stroebe, M., Stroebe, W., Schut, H., Zech, E., & van den Bout, J. (2002). Does disclosure of emotions facilitate recovery from bereavement? Evidence from two prospective studies. *Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 70* (1), 169–178. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-006X.70.1.169 19. Stroebe, M., Schut, H., & Stroebe, W. (2007). Health outcomes of bereavement. *The Lancet, 370* (9603), 1960–1973. https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736(07)61816-9 20. Williams, J., Shorter, G. W., Howlett, N., Zakrzewski-Fruer, J., & Chater, A. M. (2021). Can physical activity support grief outcomes in individuals who have been bereaved? A systematic review. *Sports Medicine – Open, 7* , 26. https://doi.org/10.1186/s40798-021-00311-z 21. Xu, Z., et al. (2024). The effect of walking on depressive and anxiety symptoms: Systematic review and meta-analysis. *JMIR Public Health and Surveillance, 10* , e48355. https://doi.org/10.2196/48355 22. Zaccaro, A., et al. (2018). How breath-control can change your life: A systematic review on psycho-physiological correlates of slow breathing. *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 12* , 353. https://doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2018.00353

A FINAL BLESSING

For the days when the book stays closed — keep just this:

"Now may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, that you may abound in hope in the power of the Holy Spirit." — Romans 15:13 (WEBU)

You are loved. You are accompanied. You are **held** .

— Wonderfully Made Labs · wonderfullymadelabs.com

More for heavy seasons: the 31-Day Prayer Companion, "Finding Christ in the Darkness," and the Still journal are free at wonderfullymadelabs.com — and the Held walking audio guide was made to keep this journal company on the path.

Soli Deo Gloria — to God alone be the glory.